Math Test Strategies

Pick one routine for your next math test. Try another one next time and keep what works.

START HERE · EVERY ROUTINE

Find out the format

Ask your teacher, then study that way.

- ☐ How many questions?
- ☐ Calculator? Which kind?
- ☐ Multiple choice or show work?
- ☐ Formula sheet or memorize?
- ☐ What topics are covered?
- ☐ How long do I have?

01 Study routines

Pick one and try it start to finish

ROUTINE A

Gap finder

Best when you're not sure what you don't know.

1. Brain dump every formula, rule, and problem type you remember on a blank page.
2. Open your notes, homework, and textbook. Circle what your page is missing.
3. Rewrite each missing piece with one worked practice problem.
4. Cover the work and redo those problems from scratch.
5. Anything you miss goes on tomorrow's list.

ROUTINE B

Mistake redo

Best when you have old quizzes and homework.

1. Pull every quiz and homework problem you got wrong this unit.
2. Cover your old work and the corrections.
3. Redo each problem from scratch.
4. Label each miss as didn't know it, careless, or misread.
5. Redo the "didn't know it" ones again two days later.

ROUTINE C

Shuffle set

Best when you freeze on which method to use.

1. Pick two problems from each section of the unit.
2. Copy each onto an index card with the answer on the back.
3. Shuffle so you can't tell which section each one came from.
4. Before solving, name the method out loud.
5. Solve, check, and shuffle the misses back in.

ROUTINE D

Talk it through

Best when examples make sense but you can't start alone.

1. Pick a worked example from your notes.
2. Cover everything except the problem.
3. Solve it, saying out loud why each step comes next.
4. Uncover it and compare one step at a time.
5. Try a similar problem with no example in sight.

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02 The week before *Spread your routine out*

Three short sessions on different days stick better than one long one the night before. Here's an example of Routine A from page 1 for a Friday test. You can of course rotate this to any day of the week.

MON · 30 MIN
Brain dump, check it against your notes, then rewrite the gaps with practice problems.

TUE · 30 MIN
Take a 30-minute self-test with practice problems.

THU · 30 MIN
Restudy everything you missed on the self-test, then finish with one more self-test.

FRI · TEST DAY
Review what you forget most right before. Formula dump first, then the tools below.

03 In the testing room *Moves to make once the test is in front of you*

Formula dump. As soon as you can write, put formulas, rules, and steps you might forget on scratch paper. Check that it's allowed.

USE IT WHEN *The test starts*

Write the goal. Box the question or write the goal in your own words, like "find every x that makes this inequality true." Include the answer's form.

USE IT WHEN *You're unsure what to solve for*

Name the type. Write what kind of problem it is in the margin, like "system of equations" or "factoring." The type points you to the method.

USE IT WHEN *You don't know which method to use*

Draw it. Sketch a picture, graph, table, or number line. Label everything you know and put a question mark on what you're looking for.

USE IT WHEN *It's a word problem or a graph*

Write the setup. List what you're given and what you know about it before you solve. Seeing it all on paper often shows you a step you missed.

USE IT WHEN *You're stuck partway through*

One move per line. One change per line keeps your work organized and easy to read, so mistakes are easier to spot.

USE IT WHEN *It takes more than two steps*

Two-minute rule. Stuck for two minutes? Mark the problem, move on, and come back with fresh eyes. Later questions can jog your memory.

USE IT WHEN *You've reread it and can't start*

Check your work. With time left, plug your answer back in, recheck signs and arithmetic, and make sure you answered every part of the question.

USE IT WHEN *You have an answer and time left*